**songs that make sense**

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# songs that make sense

by godblessgamora

Summary

she knows she's to blame, but seeing him distance himself from her is the worst kind of torture. he's everything, but she's scared that now they're nothing.
post vol 2

Notes

**this story focuses on peter's trauma and gamora's guilt after the events of vol 2.**

**the inspiration for this story is a castle episode (3x04) with this dialogue:**
**"how do you know you're in love?**
**all the songs make sense"**
**chapter 3 will be exactly about those songs that suddenly make so much sense to gamora, and chapter 1 and 2 pretty much lead up to what's happening in chapter 3.**
**the story is fully written and edited like always. posting every 5-7 days.**

**also: it's my hc that nova corps is a huge building with the lower floors being used as the offices/meeting rooms/nova prime's work space etc, but the higher floors are sort of hotel-like apartments where the guardians live when they're on xandar. i do it like this in all of my fanfics just because. i don't even know where i got the idea, but nothing can convince me guardians don't live above nova prime's office.**

# Chapter 1: chapter 1

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

She sees him die every time she closes her eyes.

She is not a stranger to nightmares, she has been plagued by them most of her life, but she has never felt this everlasting tight-gripping terror, squeezing at her heart, like she does these days. It's been days, but she keep waking up in the middle of the night, chocking on air and barely breathing.

*Where is Peter?*

She was so scared in that moment. So much more than when Mantis had called her out just mere minutes before that. She is *still* scared.

*Where is Peter?*

He is dying. All the time.

At least in her sleep.

He is dying, and she is the one who can't save him, and she wakes up night after night, barely keeping tears at bay. She relives her terror all the time, and it's too much. She doesn't know how to deal with these feelings, with these emotions of desperation and longing and *fear* and *pain* and *utter failure*.

Because he might not be actually dying now — in real life — but she also can't save him, can't *help* him, like he has saved her, like he *helped* her, and he is *pulling away*, creating *so* much distance between them, and she feels useless.

*Useless*. Pathetic. Unworthy.

She doesn't know how to fix it. How to fix *him*. Them. And she gets frustrated, night after night, because if the roles were reversed, he would know how to fix *her*. She is bad at this. Almost the worst. Sometimes she thinks that even Rocket is better at making Peter feel better.

*Rocket,* for heaven's sake.

She knew things would change. She felt it the moment he rejoined them on the ship and she practically flew into his arms, all conscious thought out of her mind, just reacting by pure instinct. He didn't hug her back. If anything, he stood almost unmoving, shoulders slumped forward, and when she broke the hug, finally catching up with the rational part of her brain because she *could not possibly be hugging him now*, she saw his red-rimmed eyes and a hollow expression in them.

“Yondu… he…” he didn’t finish, but he didn’t need to. She learned to read him well in those few months they lived together. But more than that, Yondu wasn’t right next to him, and the realization hit her like a wave. Her heart broke in two.

“Peter, I…”

She swallowed, stumbling over the words. Her heart was *bleeding* — for him. In the span of his life, he lost so much, he faced the worst of possible evils — evils he didn’t deserve — and she didn’t know what to say. How to help him.

His heartbroken expression made her want to cry.

He tried to smile, put on his usual cheerful facade, and she never hated his con side more than at that moment. She wanted him to be open, to be *honest*, to *trust* her, but she *saw* the moment the mask slipped on. She knew it was a defensive mechanism — and she knew a thing or two about them — just a means to avoid his feelings, to push it all out, and she *knew* in that moment they wouldn’t talk then.

She never expected it to last.

He *does* talk to her, to be fair. She knows that. He tries to be his usual cheerful self, to be cocky and aloof, but he avoids all of her questions. Worse than that — after the first time she attempted to talk to him, offered to hear him out, he made sure to never be around her when they were alone.

He pretends with her.

As if he doesn’t trust her.

*And maybe he doesn’t.*

The thought comes to her suddenly, and it’s something she never thought about until now, but now that the seed is planted, she sits up on her bed urgently.

They’re back on Xandar, in their fancy rooms, full of fluffy pillows and blankets that smell like an expensive perfume, and she looks around, resenting it with everything in her.

She would give everything to be back on Milano, which is *another thing that Peter lost* she thinks bitterly. She would give anything to go back in time and tell her past-self not to encourage Peter to go with Ego.

Because she did.

And he went.

Because he *trusted* her.

He trusted her, and she *broke* him. She led him straight to another heartbreak where he learned a horrible truth about his mother, lost an actual father figure, and met a *monster*.

She did it. She urged him.

She *pushed*.

She pushed, and he *lost*. Pressing her lips together, she tries to push down the bitterness, the disappointment in herself, the *resentment* she feels, but the emotions are too strong.

She feels a tear slip down, wetting her cheek.

But she doesn't move, doesn't try to brush it off, because she deserves to feel like this. She deserves this physical reminder, physical manifestation of her pain, because *she hurt the most important person in her life*.

And he is right not to trust her. To push her away.

She would do the same.

She thinks of his eyes. They were having dinner last night, and he was joking like a million times before, but his tone was too bright, to the point where she actually had to bite her lips to stop the words from leaving her mouth, from calling him out, and his eyes… She feels a lump in her throat.

His eyes were *cold*.

Empty.

And they have *never* been cold. They have *never* been empty. They have *never* been void of anything happy. Even when they used to talk about their pasts, about the dark times and the terrors they went through, his eyes were never as hollow.

*He is full of life.* Or at least, he had been in the months she has known him, and that's how she came to think of him — warm and just *so alive* — and he is nothing like that anymore, just the faux pretend that she sees through right away, and it's causing her to feel small, to hurt for him, and she never knew it could ever feel *this way*.

She knows pain. Has lived with it most of her life. But this type of pain — the pain simply because *he* is hurting — is new, unknown, confusing to her. It's suffocating, almost swallowing her whole, and she feels small, incredibly shattered.

She is happy Ego is dead. Because if he wasn't, she would hunt him down personally. She would hunt him and she would kill him no matter what it would take because he is the one who made Peter this way. Who took, what it seems, a piece of his soul and smashed it between his fingers like it was nothing. Like this piece, a part of Peter, didn't matter at all.

She growls, feeling agitated and angry again, but she welcomes the rage as it replaces the fear — not fully, but at least some of it.

But self-hatred doesn't go anywhere.

She can't save him. She can't help him. But she sure as hell can hurt him, and this breaks her heart more than anything. Hurting him is the last thing she has ever wanted to do. But it's something she excelled at.

Pushing the blanket angrily, she gets out of the bed and goes to the window to stare at the night city. It's peaceful. Calm.

Nothing like her.

She presses her forehead against the glass, feeling the coolness of it, trying to calm down. But it doesn't help, because she is the one to blame, she is the one who has caused him this pain, she is the one who left him alone with Ego in the first place, and she wants to take it all back so *he would just stop hurting*.

There is a sudden noise in the common area behind her door, and her pulse quickens as soon as she hears Peter's heartbeat. She quickly looks at the clock on her bedside table and sees that it's just past two o'clock, and she feels another wave of nausea.

He can't sleep.

Probably also plagued by nightmares.

But while she deserves them, he doesn't.

She tries to swallow, tries to calm her racing heart, but he's *there*, he is just behind her door, and they haven't been alone in days, and she just misses him, she misses being next to him with no interruptions, *she misses them*, and she knows she shouldn't go out there, he *doesn't* want to talk to her, and he *shouldn't*, but her feet carry her towards the door against her will.

She opens it quietly, and she sees Peter lean against the counter in their small kitchen. He turned the kettle on, and she sees a tea bag lying on the counter, the sight of it causing her to feel a pang of bittersweet pain. They used to share many cups of tea in the past when talking about all those heavy topics in the middle of the night.

When it was just the two of them. She knows the tea is his cure to pain. He introduced her to it. It became their thing.

Thing he apparently doesn't want to share with her anymore.

But at least he is taking care of himself, doing something that makes him feel better, and despite the pain, she feels happy about that.

He still hasn't noticed her, and she looks at him, seeing him without his mask for the first time since she hugged him on Quadrant almost a week ago.

He is not smiling now. He is not pretending to be okay. He's not pretending to be the captain who's responsible for the team and their activities. Their *entertainment*. Their *anything* — that's thing he focused on *too much* lately, claiming they all needed to have some fun after a shitty week.

He is exhausted. She sees it in his furrowed brows, in his slumped shoulders, his overall tiredness written all over his body. His head is bowed, and she can't see his expression clearly, but she doesn't need to because she has seen *enough*.

He is *not* okay.

And she just wants to help him. She just doesn't know how. She doesn't know how to fix *her* mistake.

She knows what she can do, though.

And it's to give him space and privacy.

She shouldn't be spying on him. After all, if he wanted her there with him, he would have asked her. He didn't. She tries not to bristle at the reminder — it's her fault, after all.

She is about to take a step back inside her room when his head snaps and he looks straight at her.

For a second, it's too quiet. She doesn't know what to say, but even if she did, she wouldn't be able to, not with him looking at her like that. His eyes are still empty, *terrifyingly vacant*, but even like that they're captivating, *he* is captivating, and she can't look away, she *can't see anything but him*, and she wants to both run from him and reach out to him at the same time.

She wants to help him. She is scared to hurt him even more.

He breaks the silence first.

"Can't sleep?" His voice is tired, somewhat flat.

She shakes her head.

"Sorry," she says. "I didn't mean to disturb."

He just shrugs his shoulders. "Don't worry. I'm making tea. Want some?"

Her heart flutters because he just offered her tea, he offered her a thing they shared, *one of the first things he ever shared with her*, and it means the world, but she sobers up quickly.

Tea is made for comfort. She doesn't want comfort. She doesn't deserve it. She shakes her head.

He doesn't say anything else.

It's tense. It has never been tense between them. She hates it. She knows she needs to leave, he made it perfectly clear he doesn't want to be anywhere near her, but she *can't*.

It's Peter. It's… she would blush all over her body if she could, and she knows that she from two months ago would scold her for even thinking that, but… it's her *comfort person*.

She doesn't even know where she got that name, that title. It was probably one of his figures of speech, but the fact is that *he is*, and she is like a mole while he is the flame.

She can't leave.

She can't stay away.

More than that — she *doesn't want to stay away*.

The words leave her mouth even before she processes anything.

"Do you want me to leave?"

He looks at her once again, another soul grasping, soul shattering eye contact, when nothing but him exists, and she is terrified of his response, of his *yes*, but she is also bracing herself for it. He surprises her, though, when he shakes his head.

"No."

There is both relief and fear.

*She wants to be close to him. She is scared of hurting him even more.*

She pushes it all out of her mind, though. He just let her stay with him. It's about him. Not about her and her feelings. She can deal with those later. For now, she needs to do everything she can for him.

Because it's all about him.

It's been about him since the moment they met.

She still tried to deny it even a week ago. And then he almost died — twice — and all the denial ended. She takes a tentative step towards him, but then changes her mind and goes to the couch in the adjacent living room. The kettle just boiled, and he is making his cup of tea. It's his choice whether to join her or stay far away.

She made a choice for him with Ego. She will not corner him again.

Her whole body feels alive when he joins her, though. He doesn't say anything, and she is at loss for words, scared, anxious, but also hopeful, and it's too much, and usually it takes his smile for her to feel grounded, to feel calm, to feel like *it's okay to feel things because he is right there to help her*, but she can't ask for it right now, she shouldn't, so she tries to take a deep breath and faces him.

Her face must show something, because he abruptly asks her a question. "It was a cool dinner, right?"

And the switch is on. His voice is bright. Too bright. A smile she wished for just a second ago is back, but she instantly hates it, because it's fake, *not hers*, and it's all wrong. She

humours him, though. "Yeah," she says, making her lips split into a fake smile. "I really like those burgers."

"See! I told you Terran food is super good!" There is a glimpse of something in his eyes, but it's too fleeting for her to name the emotion.

They used to talk a lot about Terran food. At nights when her walls were down, she let herself dream of trying them one day, maybe not on Terra, but at least a replacement here in space, knowing he would be there to share the experience with her.

It was nothing like she dreamed last night.

She didn't even feel the taste of food. She hasn't done that in days — not since Ego. She somehow feels that he hasn't either.

He doesn't want to talk to her, and she wants to respect it, *respect him*, but she hates this false pretence. She hates knowing he doesn't trust her, because she is the one who started it all. She is torn.

Bringing her knees to her chest, she hugs her legs, trying to become small, almost *nonexistent*, because she is sure it would be better for him, *so much easier*. But she's is *hurting*, her whole body, her heart, her *soul*, the one she doesn't believe she has, not with her actions, with what she's caused him, and she feels the tears prickling at her eyes, and it can't be happening, *she can't have a breakdown in front of him*, not when he is the one going through hell right now, so she turns away from him trying to hide her face.

He doesn't let her, though.

"Gamora?"

And that's when she loses it because there is *concern* in his voice. Actual concern, deep worry she can't mistake with anything else, and she feels *so bad.*

A sob leaves her lips, shoulders rocking with it, and she tries to keep quiet, tries to muffle it, because she has no right whatsoever to worry him when he is already just a shadow of his usual self, but his concern, his unmistakable *caring* that she hasn't felt in days, the caring she convinced herself she didn't care about and didn't miss, but oh god she did, *she did so much*, and it's all just too good and too bad at the same time.

His hand is suddenly on her shoulders and he is moving closer to her, and she feels his heartbeat pick up and his breathing increases.

"Gamora…" there's desperation in his voice.

The tone is raspy, almost breathless, as if it pains him to say her name, and there's something else there, something she doesn't want to name, because then she will want more of it, and she shouldn't, but *she already does*, and she can't stop the tears, and her shoulders shake violently.

She’s never had a breakdown in front of him.

He saw her tear up.

But this?.. This is the first. And she can’t believe it’s happening *now*.

Stupid.

She is so stupid.

She tries to take a deep breath, but she can’t, and then suddenly he is enveloping her in a hug, and she missed it so much. She missed *him* so much — his touch, his smell, his proximity. She can’t help it when she turns to look at him, and her tears cloud her vision, so he’s blurry, but he’s *there*, and she is suddenly clutching his shirt in her fists, scared to let go.

She is scared he will disappear.

She is scared he will change his mind.

She is scared he will see she’s unworthy. Or even worse — he *already* sees that she is.

She is scared that he will not be okay.

She is scared she won’t be okay. Because she can never be okay if he isn’t.

She is scared their unspoken thing won’t be a thing anymore.

She is scared for *them*.

Because she wants them, she wants it more than anything, but she knows she can’t give him much, she can’t give *anything*, and he deserves the world, and she needs to let go, but the fear of doing that, of him actually leaving makes her cling to him like her life depends on it because *it does*.

Both her life and her sanity.

Everything.

Because *he is everything*.

She cries, feeling his arms around her, his pulse in his neck next to her cheek, his rapid heartbeat, his fingers stroking her gently, and she just cries, because she hasn’t allowed herself to do that, and she feels so much, and he’s here, and he’s catching her, and it’s *everything* she was scared she lost.

She doesn’t know how much time passes, but eventually she calms down, surrounded by his smell, his heartbeat, and his soft breathing above her. He hugs her, holds her tightly, and she has never felt more safe than whenever she’s in his arms.

She wants to give him the same.

He is her comfort person. It's clingy and needy and so not assassin-like, but she doesn't care. She never does, not when it comes to him.

She just wants to be a comfort person for him, too.

She is not sure how.

And it's the god damn problem.

Pressing her lips together, feeling another wave of despair for being absolutely useless, she tries to calm down, stay present here with him rather than in her own head, but she gets riled up in a nanosecond anyway, her breath hitching in her throat.

Peter notices.

He always does.

He moves away from her to look down, and there's undeniable concern, a worry that tugs at her heart, and he touches her face, sending goosebumps down her body, brushing her hair away from her wet face.

"Do you want to tell me about it?" His voice is barely above whisper.

Her instinct is to say *no*, to tell him she is fine, because god, he is already going through so much even without her baggage, and it should be *her* questioning *him*, trying to make him open up, but then she suddenly thinks how unfair that is. She can't brush him off, she can't *lie* to him with an obvious *no*, and expect him to be honest with her.

She has to be the strong one.

She has to open up to him.

Because maybe, just maybe, he will do the same in return.

"Yes," she says after a while. "I just…" She doesn't know what to say. All words suddenly seem foreign, too difficult to say out loud.

There is too much she is worrying about.

Him dying in her dreams. Him possibly dying any time in real life given that there is nothing godly in him anymore.

Him pushing her away, intensifying her fears she is the evil. Her not being enough for him.

*Them*. Them not becoming anything more, because he deserves everything, and she is nothing, especially after pushing him towards Ego and making him lose his actual parental figure and Walkman, his connection to his mother, his safe haven, his comfort zone. She doesn't know how to articulate any of that, because feelings aren't her things, it's his, and she

is being selfish because it's not about her, but she can't help it. She feels it with every cell in her body.

She is just scared. Unknown has always been her worst enemy.

"I just…" she takes a deep breath, trying to ground herself, stall some time, but then says the first thing that comes to her mind that second. "I see you die. In my dreams. All the time."

His face, already incredibly sad, full of anxiety and worry, falls even more. An icy chill grips her heart.

"I'm sorry." His voice is full of agony now. Her insides twist into a tight knot when she realizes he is *blaming* himself.

Oh no.

He is blaming himself.

His heart, his soul is too pure for this galaxy. No one here deserves him.

She reaches out, touching his forehead, trying to smooth out the wrinkles there, trying to erase the worry from his face, and he leans into her touch. Her heart stutters.

"Don't be," her voice is soft, quiet, but full of assertiveness. "It's not your fault."

He doesn't say anything after that, just looks at her, so close yet so far away. She needs to say something, she knows that, and her body takes over, making her open up to him without her conscious decision on what she is going to say.

"You almost died that day twice, and I… I was terrified the first time, but when Rocket…" she has to stop, to swallow a lump in her throat, because she still remembers her frantic *Where's Peter?* and Rocket's pitiful eyes, and it breaks her even now, days later. "I just… I just found you, Peter. I *can't* lose you."

He seems to be at loss for words, and it's probably the first time she sees him struggle with what to say back. It would be adorable if it wasn't so heartbreaking.

"You…" she takes a pause to take a deep breath before she just plunges forward. "You're the most infuriating person I have ever met," and that actually makes him smile a bit, and her heart flutters. It's a small win, but she will take anything at this point. "But you're also the most…" *important*, but there is *no way she is ever saying that*, but then her body has better ideas, and of course she ends up blurting it out, "important."

His eyes grow twice in size. His breath hitches in his throat, and she guesses she is finally admitting about their unspoken thing, but when she thinks of how much he has been avoiding her and how much he might not want that anymore, her mood drops, stomach clenching painfully.

But she pushes forward. Now that she's open this box of feelings that should not be said out loud, she feels the need to express it all.

*The dam has broken.* It's another expression he taught her, and she finally gets what it's like.

"I know… I know it's my fault," and she sees him open his mouth, confusion passing in his eyes, but she rushes to continue. "And… I get it. You blame me. You're avoiding me, but…" He tries again, but she doesn't stop there. "But, Peter, it's… I am a warrior and an assassin, but you are you, and I just… it's…"

She doesn't even know what to say.

She has no coherent thoughts.

Just feelings.

Because he *is*, and it *is*, and she *is*, and her heart beats for him, breaks for him, and years for him. She is trying to come up with the correct words, growing silent for a second, and Peter uses this chance to speak.

"Your what?" His voice is practically scandalized, he is whisper yelling, even leaning further away from her. "Your *fault*?"

She just looks at him, not sure how to reply to that. But he is obviously waiting for a reaction, so she nods. That doesn't seem to be the best move, though. He goes from confused to agitated in a second.

He pushes his hand through his hair, tugging at it, and closing his eyes. Taking a couple deep breaths, he seems to be trying to get his emotions under control, and she is so confused by this reaction, by pure agony and hatred she sees on his face, that she almost flinches back.

"How…" he says after a while, but his emotions are so strong he has to swallow. He lapses back into the silence for another second, before opening his eyes. "What are you talking about?"

She stares at him blankly.

"It was me who pushed you to go to his planet," she says in a moment, when it's clear he is not going to say anything until she does. Her tone is slow, controlled, but there's tension there, because she doesn't like talking about her mistakes. "You knew something was wrong, and I pushed, and then I said we would kill him. I gave you a promise, but the price for that was…"

"Stop," he says vehemently, and it's an oder, and she would kill anyone else for telling her what to do, but it's him, so she *listens*.

They're silent. The air around them is stiff.

His heart is galloping, and he is still gripping his hair, his knuckles white from the tension.

She almost reaches out to swat at his arm, because she is sure he is hurting himself. Knowing that he does it voluntarily, harms himself in even such a simple way, chips another piece of her soul.

“Gamora,” he says, voice strained, as if each syllabus is a challenge. “Stop. I can’t believe you went *there*.”

“Where?” She almost snaps, and she doesn’t even know why, but the disbelief and disappointment — *disappointment!* — in his voice make her bristle away.

“To the land of that absolute nonsense,” he says with a final certainty. She opens her mouth to argue, but he beats her to it. “That was, *in no way*, your fault.”

She wants to say something. Wants to disagree, to convince him and make him see how unworthy she is — like she’s been trying to tell him for months — but something cold creeps up her neck.

She doesn’t believe she is *not* to blame, but if he does…

“Then why have you been avoiding me?”

The question leaves her lips before she even registers it, and she almost visibly winces from how hurt she sounds. There’s a hint of accusation, though, and he can read it, and he sighs tiredly, and suddenly she wants to be anywhere but here.

Because if he doesn’t blame her, it means…

Her chest constricts.

It means…

She can’t even finish the thought.

She doesn’t want to finish the thought. But the words appear in her mind despite that.

He avoids her because he doesn’t want her. Doesn’t need her. *Not anymore.*

She has only one instinct — to run — but she also can’t make her body move even an inch. She is paralyzed, sitting here with her knees under her chin, cold from the inside, looking at him.

He is not looking at her.

He has leaned forward, pressing his elbows into his knees, and his hands are still in his hair, still tugging, still harming, and she wants to tell him to stop, but she can’t, because none of the muscles in her body work, and she is just scared.

He is close to her, so close. She could touch him without fully extending her arm, but she has never felt farther from him than in this moment.

The inches separating them could be millions of jump points at this point.

The silence is too much to take, because the longer he is silent, the more things she can come up with. And none of them are good. She is not an optimist like him. She can't stay positive. So she breaks the silence.

"Why?" Her voice breaks, and she suddenly realizes she's started crying again. It's not nerve wrecking sobs anymore, just silent tears sliding down her cheeks. She wipes them off angrily, wishing to stay calm, appear okay, but she *isn't* and *none* of this is okay.

He lifts his head up, looks at her, and she chokes on air, on her tears, hastily pressing fingers against her mouth to stifle the sound. His eyes are full of tears, lips twisted in a grimace. He looks absolutely heartbroken, and it breaks *her*. She finally sees *how much he is hurting*, and it absolutely destroys her. It's something she needed — to see that he still trusts her, still shares with her more than anyone else, as stupid and clingy and childish as that feeling was — but now that she sees his pain, she wishes she never did.

He is hurting, and she is hurting with him.

"Peter," she whispers, just because she needs to say something, *can't* just stay silent.

She pushes all of her own insecurities and worries away, because even if he doesn't want her anymore, even if there's no unspoken thing, she can't just ignore his misery and sadness. Her feelings aren't important now. His are.

She scoots closer without thinking and touches his back with her fingers. He jerks from the movement, but doesn't pull away, doesn't tell her to stop, and she takes it as a signal that it's okay.

That maybe he wants to be comforted.

She half hugs him, pressing her cheek again his back, and both of her arms envelope him, and she prays to every deity that this is enough. She knows this won't heal anything, but she needs him to stop hurting.

"He killed my mom."

His voice is a rigged whisper, anguish so clear that she stops breathing for a second. There is so much pain, anger, and loathing, but worse than that she can hear desperation, and she suddenly realizes that he just lost his mom all over again.

She is positive he has never loved anyone or anything as much as his mom. She can't even imagine what he might be feeling now after learning that that she was *killed*.

He was broken by her death as it is. Learning that she could have been alive all this time if it wasn't for his psychopathic father is a shock to the system. She knows. Her mother is dead because of her "father" too.

She tries to come up with words, with anything to say, but there is nothing, because nothing can take away his pain. She knows that. So she says the only thing she can:

“I’m so sorry.”

“She could have been alive.”

“I know,” she says sadly.

“I hate him.”

“I know.” She hates him, too.

“He took everything from me.” Peter takes a shaky breath, wiping his tears, and turns to look at her. He looks like a little boy. Scared. Heartbroken. Lost. “He killed her. He took my Walkman. He took *Yondu.*” His voice breaks at that. “Even Milano. If it wasn’t for him, we might have had a chance to repair it all together somehow — if we never left. And now I don’t have any of it, and he took, and I…”

She hugs him tighter, squeezing the bare skin on his arms. It’s freezing to the touch. She suddenly notices he is shaking. Not just from the tears, but from the cold. She wants to put him in a million blankets. His heart is beating erratically, but so is hers.

“I just… I hate it. Hate *him*,” he says.

“I know,” she says gently. “So do I.”

“I know I need to move on, but I can’t. He made her sick. He killed her.”

“I wish I could change everything.” And that’s the most honest thing she’s ever told him. If there was even a slight chance to erase his pain and rewrite the past, she would. In a heartbeat.

He grows silent for a while, and she keeps hugging him. Never in her life she initiated physical contact, let alone prolonged it. But with him, she does. Because he is different. He is *everything*.

She rubs his arms gently, just up and down, short strokes meant to comfort, to reassure — something he did for her in the past, sending a wave of longing and gratitude through her entire body — but she still feels how tense he is, his muscles hard, flexed, to the point where she is sure it’s not normal.

Especially not now when he doesn’t possess any celestial abilities.

And then it occurs to her. She curses mentally for not realizing it sooner.

*Of course* he is tense. Because she used to be too. In the beginning, when it was just the two of them in the Milano’s cockpit in the middle of the night, her plagued by her nightmares and him being there to catch her when needed.

She remembers being anxious. She also remembers his gentle expression, his careful — respectful and *meant to comfort* — touch, his sincere eyes. She remembers not understanding the gentleness. Being scared of it. Yet longing for it all the same.

Because she never had it. Not until him. She never had a safe space to let go and just be, and it suddenly occurs to her that he never had that either.

*I got you. I just want to help.* She remembers him saying that, looking at her with nothing but compassion and genuine concern. It was a hard night shortly after defeating Ronan. She had dreamed of Thanos getting angry, wanting to get revenge and harming Peter as a result. She never told him what the nightmare was about, but she remembers it vividly even now.

It was the first night she dreamed of him.

The first night of many.

*I got you.* And he *did* get her. He helped her. He surrounded her with nothing but warmth and support, and she trusted him, she opened up — at least about some stuff — and he was there to catch her when she fell, paralyzed by her own emotions. She didn't have a breakdown that night. But she felt so cold, so small, so *unworthy* she couldn't say anything. She got stuck in her own head, not seeing anything around her. Just listening to the voice inside.

*Unworthy. Unworthy. Unworthy.*

She trembled, gasping for air, throat closed up, tight, while she was plagued by the images supplied by her mind.

He sank in front of her on his knees and touched her cheek. And he brought her back to reality, gently urging her to breath with him. He sat on the cold floor for what seemed like hours, inhaling and exhaling stiff air, guiding her with his words, until her heart slowed down.

And then he brought her a cup of tea and told her about his mother. He gave her a distraction, knowing she needed it the most in the moment.

And she suddenly knows, she is sure of it more than anything else in her life, that right now he needs the same. He just needs to be reassured. To be held.

He needs to be *caught*.

Because no one has ever done that for him, and she suddenly realizes for the first time how deep his trauma is. How carefully he guards it behind the mask, and how no one just gets it.

How *she* never got it. Not until now. Not until she heard hoarse voice filled with pain and heartbreak. Not until she saw red rimmed eyes that replaced the vacant stare he's had for days.

“I’m here.” She tells him. He tenses even more, as if the words are unwelcome, and maybe they are, but she means them, so she goes on. “I got you. I just want to help.”

She doesn’t know if he remembers saying the same thing to her, but it doesn’t matter. She means it. He starts trembling against her, and his skin is icy to her touch, she feels it, and she’s had enough.

She can’t erase his emotional pain. But she will help him with his physical discomfort.

She breaks the contact between them, straightening up, and he makes a chocking noise, but she immediately grabs his hand.

“Shh,” she whispers quietly. “It’s okay.”

She tugs on his arm, urging him to get up, and he looks at her questioningly.

“Come on. Let’s get you to bed.”

For a second, his expression gets even more heartbroken than it was before. But he scolds himself and then his face is just *blank*. It’s as if they took a hundred steps back. She tries not to let that affect her. “If you wish so.”

He lets go go her arm, stands up from the couch, and turns into the direction of his room. She realizes her mistake.

“No,” she says hurriedly. “I didn’t mean that. I meant my room. Unless you prefer yours. But *I’m not leaving you*.”

“Oh.”

He looks like a lost boy again. So vulnerable. “You… you changed the topic so quickly… I thought you had enough.” He says quietly.

“Of what?” She is confused.

“Of me.”

Her heart drops.

She takes a tentative step towards him. “Never.”

And this is the most open she’s ever been. She grabs his hand and tugs at it towards her room. Once inside, she lightly pushes him towards the bed.

“Get under the covers. You’re freezing.”

“So demanding,” he says half-absently, probably trying to joke, to lighten everything up, but not having enough energy to actually make it sound like a joke.

"Yes. So do as I say," she says firmly but gently.

He must have been more cold than she thought, because he slides under the covers in a flash, tugging the blanket towards him until there is nothing but his eyes that are visible from underneath it. He's curled up in a ball, she can see the outline of his body, and she feels another tug of pain at her heart.

He doesn't deserve this pain.

Any pain, actually.

"I'm still cold," he whispers to her after a while.

"Would you like…" *to have another blanket,* but the words die on her lips. She doesn't think he talks about the physical cold. At least, not completely. "What can I do to help?"

She remembers him asking her this. Instead of assuming, *he just asked her*. Something no one had ever done before him.

He looks at her, eyes equally full of longing and anguish. She knows he wants something. She also knows he is denying himself. She takes a tentative step towards him.

"I got you," she whispers. Trying to reassure him, to tell him it's okay to want. "I'm right here."

"Not for long," he says so quietly, mumbling into the fabric of the blanket, that there is no way she would have heard this if it wasn't for her enhanced hearing.

She feels her pulse pick up, confusion and panic coursing through her body. His tone is full of certainty, despite the quietness and trembling of his voice, that she gets cold chills running down her spine.

"Are you… are you going somewhere?" She asks, swallowing the lump.

He shakes his head.

"You are."

"Me?" She is officially lost. Taking couple steps forward, she reaches the edge of the bed and sits down. "Why would I go somewhere?"

"Why wouldn't you?"

He looks at her, tears welling up in his eyes, and she can't stand it anymore. She has to touch him. She has to reassure him. Reaching out her hand, she touches his face, brushing off the tears sliding down his cheeks, and she is an absolute mess.

It's like someone is ripping her heart out. And then squeezing it, making it impossible for it to beat anymore.

“Lie with me?”

His question catches her off guard. It’s a sudden topic change, but also his voice — seconds ago full of certainty, but now so unsure — make it hard for her to process his words for a second. He has never sounded unsure. He radiates confidence miles away.

But she nods. Eagerly.

Not just for him, but for her.

He dies in her dreams. And he has created this distance between them in real life. Seeing her lose him in her sleep has been painful enough. Waking up to him actually pushing her away, her actually *losing him*, has been worse than any of Thanos’ torture.

She will give him anything he wants.

She will take whatever he wants to give.

She lies on top of covers, inches away from his face, and finally says:

“I’m not going anywhere.”

He grows even sadder than he was just a second ago, not that she thought it was possible.

“I wish I could believe that.”

It’s like he just stabbed her. She immediately feels tears prickling at her eyes, but pushes any bitterness down. He has every right to say that. He has every right not to trust her.

She takes couple deep breaths to calm herself down before replying.

“I deserve that.” She sounds resigned. “But, Peter—“

“What?” He interrupts her.

“I deserve you not trusting me,” she says in a small voice. Even saying this out loud twists a knife even deeper into her heart. She’s bleeding, bleeding, *bleeding*.

“What?” His tone goes from heartbroken to scandalized in a heartbeat. “Gamora, I…” he takes a moment to collect his thought, his voice raw with emotions. With shock, with pain, with unbelievability. “You think I don’t trust you?”

And then it’s like they’re back in time. Back on that couch half an hour earlier. Back to him saying that nothing that happened was her fault and her asking why he has been ignoring her.

A knife goes even deeper.

She doesn’t know how it can go that deep. She doesn’t know how it can hurt this much. This moment, she suddenly wishes she never met him — not if knowing him can bring her so much pain. But then she feels bad, so bad, because even with this pain, with this soul

crushing fear she is feeling, she knows he is the best thing that ever happened to her and she wouldn't change it for the world.

"Why have you been avoiding me, then?" She asks when she can find the words again.

It's back to this. She shouldn't, but she can't help it.

His mouth opens.

"That's… you think it's because I don't trust you?" She hears the disbelief in his voice.

"Either that. Or…" *because you don't want me anymore. Because you don't think I can help you. Because you… because you don't love me anymore.* But she says none of that, because her throat closes up, words get stuck, and she has to swallow them, feeling them land at the pit of her stomach.

"Gamora," his tone is both pleading and chastising. "You can't possibly be thinking that."

"Then why?" She asks, the question sounds like a plea, and she guesses it is, because she's asked him four times now — *four!* — and he hasn't replied, and she can't take this anymore.

She needs to know.

He gets his arm out from underneath the blanket and touches her cheek, trying to brush off the tears that fell without her knowing, and she crumbles under his touch. It's gentle. But he has been avoiding her. He has been suffering in pain alone. He died six nights in a row in her sleep. It's all just too much.

"Why?" She chokes on her tears.

"Because…" the words get stuck again. He growls angrily, and she can barely see him from the tears that cloud her vision. "Because I already lost so much. I can't lose you too." His voice breaks. "Everything that I have ever loved… ever cared about… it's gone. It's all gone," she hears pain, so much pain. "I don't want you to be gone too. So I… I'd rather avoid you than… than tempt the fate to take you away."

It takes her a second to process what he is saying, but when she does, there's a sound escaping her throat, something between a growl — of frustration, at her — and a choke — of pain, directed at him — because *oh my god.* (Another expression he's taught her).

For someone who comes across as very easygoing, he is so much more than that, much more than his quips and pans, because there is just so much trauma there. Unresolved trauma, eating him alive, suppressed for years, even decades, and she *should have known*, but she didn't, and now she feels so *useless*.

He has always been the best at comforting her, at knowing what she needed.

And she just proved that she couldn't do the same for him.

She doesn't deserve him. Another reminder. Another proof. And the instinct to run, to make him free of her is strong. But there is something even more prevalent, and the sudden realization is enough to knock all the wind out of her, almost making her gasp.

*She doesn't want to run.*

She wants to stop. *For* him.

*With* him.

Because she wants to be enough for him. And *with* him. And *for* her, too.

She is silent for too long, she realizes too late, when Peter rushes to fill the silence between them.

"So… that's… not on you." He clears his throat. "I just…"

But she interrupts him because she can't let him take any blame for this.

"I'm so sorry," she whispers, and then she's touching him, cupping his cheeks, his jaw, desperately trying to hold onto him, to make him see how much he means to her. "I'm so sorry."

*For everything.*

*For not understanding you sooner.*

*For thinking of my own pain more.*

*For not being enough.*

*For convincing you to go to Ego.*

*For taking so long to figure everything out.*

But Peter just shakes his head.

"No, Gamora, it's… you have nothing to apologize for." She presses a finger to his lips, silencing him. His skin is still so cold.

"I do, Peter."

He vehemently shakes his head once again, eyes full of determination now. "You don't. Because I *shouldn't have* ignored you, and I *did. Intentionally.* Because I thought I needed to distance myself from you, because you will also disappear," his voice is hollow, yet undeniably sad. "I hurt you."

"You didn't." Her own fears did.

She looks at him, earnest, open, trying to make him see she is telling the truth, and her heart breaks at the sight of tears in his eyes. She brushes them off.

“How can I make it better?”

The question easily slips from her lips. She doesn’t know how to make it better. But she can at least ask. And maybe it’s going to be the first step.

He is silent, tears pulling in his eyes faster now.

“I’m not used to this.”

And she hears what he actually means — to people caring, to people asking, to people listening, to people seeing *the real him*, all masks gone. She knows, because the roles are reversed now. She was the one who wasn’t used to this months ago. And he taught her. He showed her.

She is going to do the same for him now.

“I know,” she says quietly, slightly nodding her head. “But I’m here. For whatever you need.”

He looks at her, his gaze is piercing her right through her soul, and she shivers. She loves his eyes.

“Just stay with me,” he says after a while, and she knows this isn’t about tonight. This isn’t about this bed or this room. This is about more. This is about *not losing*.

She needs him to stay with her too.

“For as long as you need me to.” She says earnestly, but she also thinks, *for as long as I can*. She wishes she could say forever. But there’s Thanos. There’s their jobs. There’s just so much danger.

His breath hitches in his throat, and he nods. She smiles softly. This seems like the first step.

There is about a million more, but somehow it’s okay.

Chapter End Notes

**sdcc 2022 ruined me, and i can't even go anywhere near those "i thought you were gone but you're here and i miss you" and "that person isn't me" lines. but i will, so i guess some angsty fanfics are coming soon. but also happy end ones too.**

# Chapter 2: chapter 2

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

The idea comes to her suddenly, very impulsively, but her life has been exactly that — *very impulsive* — ever since she met Peter, so it almost seems fitting.

It's been a few days since that night, since they talked but also *not really:* they discussed stuff, but left so many things unsaid — and it's both better and worse at the same time.

He doesn't pretend with her anymore, but he is still grieving. Whenever they're alone, it's like he shrinks twice in size, eyes immediately dull and blank, shoulders slumped forward, and her heart breaks every time.

She doesn't know how to make it all better because he is still pretending with everyone else, he is still not really talking about his feelings, shoving them deep down — like she has been doing all of her life — and she just tries to come up with something that would put a smile on his face.

She thinks about *anything at all* all the time, and when the idea finally comes, she almost feels giddy because it just feels right. If that won't make Peter smile, then she is not sure that anything else will, so she pushes down her doubts and worries and focuses on *achieving*.

She is good at that. She knows how to get something done. She has been taught to excel at it. So excel she will.

She is at the gym, another courtesy of Nova Corps, and she knows she needs to change, but she also knows that Peter is upstairs, most likely hanging out in the common area, and there is no way she will be able to run away from him to see Nova Prime on her own.

So she swallows her discomfort because she still likes to follow the rules, and she knows you're not supposed to meet with the commander looking like that, and marches few floors down.

If the guards are disturbed by her appearance, they're not showing their disapproval, and she's grateful. Reaching Nova Prime's office, she sees Nova Prime's assistance, and she smiles at the girl.

"Miss Gamora," the girl says brightly, smiling wide. "How can I help you?"

This type of treatment is still surreal to her. Few short months ago she made people fear the mere mention of her name. Now, they smile at her.

It's crazy what a turn life can take.

“I’m sorry I came unannounced,” Gamora says apologetically after a second of silence. “I was wondering if I can see Nova Prime some time soon? I have something urgent to discuss.”

“Did something happen?” The girl asks worriedly, and Gamora feels bad for not remembering her name. “No, no. Nothing like that. It’s… something personal,” she says awkwardly.

The girl nods, then checks her holo quickly. After a second, she says:

“I can fit you in right now, actually. If you could just wait over there, please,” and she mentions towards some benches in the corner.

Gamora smiles at her gratefully.

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“Miss Gamora,” Nova Prime says warmly, once Gamora is in the office, having greeted the commander. “How can I help you?”

Gamora takes a deep breath, feeling severely undressed and absolutely unprofessional, but what she is about to ask has nothing to do with professionalism, so she just goes for it.

“I was wondering…” she takes a second to find a way to word her request, “if it’s possible to somehow be connected to the Terran’s satellite network? Or whatever it is that would let us watch Terran movies?”

Nova Prime doesn’t seem too surprised by this request, she just nods with a small smile, as if she expected this all along. Maybe she has. She has met Peter, after all. Anyone who has met him knows of his love for Terran culture.

“That could be arranged,” she says. “I could ask our technicians to work on a holopad. It shouldn’t take longer than a few hours.”

Gamora feels an intense relief, finally breathing deeply for the first time in minutes, only now realizing how tense and scared she was that it would not be possible. So many things went wrong for him. She wouldn’t have been surprised if this one didn’t work out too.

She nods, gratefully smiling at Nova Prime. She hopes the commander can see the deep gratitude in her eyes.

“Would you like me to bring you my holo?”

“I don’t think that would be necessary. My technicians can work on a new one, and then you can come check it out and submit your biometrics so it would be wired to you. Unless you prefer for them to work on your current one, of course.”

Gamora shakes her head.

“It’s fine.”

Nova Prime nods.

“Then, I will stop by their office and ask them to work on it. Once it’s done, they’re going to contact you directly, so you could come and see if everything is to your preference.”

She thinks she could hug this woman right now.

“Thank you,” she says, voice rich with everything she is feeling right now. “I appreciate your help.”

“That’s the least I could do for you, Miss Gamora. Both you and Peter, along with the rest of the team, helped Xandar — the entire Universe — more times that we can count.”

Gamora just nods, overwhelmed with emotions. It’s surreal to be on the receiving end of praise. And scary, too. But not as scary as in the beginning when the only instinct was to run. Now, it’s just scary, because for the first time in her life she has so much to lose and she doesn’t want that to happen.

***

The rest of the day goes quickly, blur of anxiety and anticipation and unjustified worry that *something will definitely go wrong* because *when everything went right*, and she spends the majority of the time in her room.

When the ping finally comes, she reaches for her holo right away. There’s an encrypted message for her from one of the technicians and she hops off her bed.

Finally.

She’s ready to run to their floor to grab the enhanced holo. Yet, when she opens the door, she almost smashes into Peter. His arms come around her shoulders to stop her from falling — not that she ever would, not with her improved stability — but the contact is welcome.

He looks down at her, eyes not as vacant as few days before. Her heart flutters.

“Hey, you okay?” He asks her. “Haven’t seen you much today.”

His tone is sad but reserved, as if he doesn’t want to admit what he just said — and she guesses he doesn’t because he still doesn’t believe, he still expects something bad to happen, and that’s the reason why she is doing what she is doing.

“Yeah. I was just… busy,” she says vaguely.

That sounds awful even to her own ears. Peter, being an excellent liar and master of trickery, just raises his eyebrows in question. He knows something is up.

She feels bad for lying, but she doesn’t want to spoil her surprise. She wants to see his true emotions once he sees what she’s done.

“I will tell you later,” she promises, smiling softly.

He nods and doesn’t push. Breaking the contact between them, he takes a step back. He is no longer touching her, and she feels the loss of his warmth immediately. The sadness she’s feeling is absolutely ridiculous but also incredibly familiar at this point.

It’s always like that when he breaks off the physical contact.

“The guys actually wanted to hit a bar,” Peter says after a moment of silence. “Want to join us?”

Oh.

“You’re going out?”

“Yes,” he furrows. “Why?”

She wants him to stay here. But she pushes it down — he seems to be eager. His voice isn’t as hollow as it used to be.

“No reason,” she reassures him with a forced smile. “But no, I’m going to stay in. Have fun, though.”

“You sure?”

She nods. He sighs but nods as well. He seems disappointed — not at her, just in general — but she sees him push his emotions down, and it makes her stomach knot.

She doesn’t want him to push anything down.

Not his trauma. Not his fears. Not his disappointment.

She wants him to share because she knows how suppressed feelings poison your body, your mind, your *entire soul.* She doesn’t want that for him. So she says, “You know what? Never mind what I just said. I will join you guys. I just need to get something done first.”

He beams for a second, but then scolds his expression, and he’s suppressing again, trying not to get too excited, too happy, because he beliefs she’s going to leave him too, and he doesn’t want to get too comfortable, and she swallows the pain down.

More than anything, she doesn’t want him to push down his happiness. Because pushing it down means denying. Depriving. And he should never depreciate himself of happiness. He deserves every little single ounce of it.

Reaching out, she takes his hand because she craves physical contact with him, she needs reassurance of his warm skin, and smiles, trying to be open for both of them.

“I will see you soon, Peter, I promise.”

*I won’t leave you. I’m going to be right there with you.*

He nods, expression carefully guarded, but she sees glimpses of gratitude in his eyes. It's not enough, but it's there.

Squeezing his hand, she moves past him. Hopefully, by the time she is back, they're gone. She doesn't want him to see the holo before the time is right.

***

"So, we have changed the hardware and the software of this holopad, accessing the Terran's communication protocols." The technician girl explains to her. "Basically, through the satellites…" Gamora kind of scrunches her nose almost mindlessly, and the girl chuckles. "Right. Sorry."

What she is good at is kicking ass. What she is very bad at is anything technology related. Plus, she doesn't really need to know how it works. She's just going to be happy with a fact that it does.

"Basically, it means you can access Terran's internet as if you were on Terra, as the holopad is wired to the protocols used there." The girl continues. "However, I must warn you, Terran's technology is beyond primitive, and it's not compatible with our devices."

"And is that a problem?" She is a bit lost.

"Not necessarily," the girl shrugs her shoulders. "All it means, is that you can't use the holo to surf across our protocol network systems. Basically, it's useless in Space."

"Well, I have my own holo for that," Gamora says. "So as long as I can access Terran movies, it should be good."

"You will be able to do that," the girl says brightly. "Look," she shows at some icons on the screen, "I have installed the major streaming services used by the humans. Each of them have their own collection, but between all of them you should have access to the majority of movies."

"Majority? But not all?" Gamora asks, suddenly worried. "How do I know which service to use?"

The girl practically beams at her, excited to show her how everything worlds, and she reminds Gamora of Peter, of his childlike excitement, and she can't help but smile softly.

She spends the next few minutes learning about the apps and the names because they don't make much sense — what the hell is Prime Video after all — and this is so much more that she ever expected, and she feels confused.

There are many choices, however, and that makes her feel better. The more options Peter will have, the happier he will be. And the happier he is, the more content she feels.

She specifically looks for Star Wars movies to make sure they're there, and then she checks for Footloose, and finding both, she feels even happier.

Peter is going to love it.

*No he will not.* But she pushes the voice of insecurity down.

He will. Because it's been years since he last saw these movies, and she knows how much he would love to do it, and her worry is pointless.

He is going to be so excited. He *is*.

Because if he is not… she will personally go on a quest to find a Time Stone to kill Ego before Peter ever met him. Because if he is not going to be excited… it means Ego ruined him beyond any repair. And that can't happen.

It just *can't.*

Swallowing sudden bitterness and anger, Gamora looks at the girl.

"I also installed the music app for you!" She supplies, voice as eager as before. "Look."

She ends up taking few more minutes explaining to her how Spotify works, showing her various albums, artists, and playlists, listing all the functions of the app. Gamora's eyes grow twice in size once she realizes the full potential.

Peter's Zune — and Walkman, for that matter — can play only a limited number of songs, the ones that are already installed. This app, however, gives access to millions of songs, letting users remotely access whatever they want to listen to.

Peter can find new things he likes. He can finally *have* rather than *lose.* This realization almost knocks all air out of her, and feeling her heart clench, she looks at girl, at loss for words.

This is beyond what she has ever hoped for.

"Thank you so much. You have no idea what this means."

Her voice is thick with emotions. It's also trembling.

"Oh, no worries!" The girl — and Gamora should really learn her name, but the girl is not wearing a name tag — says. "I haven't seen something so outdated, like, *ever,* but it was fun playing with the reprogramming."

Gamora just nods.

The girl seems to realize the importance of the moment and turns around to pretend to do something else to give Gamora a moment.

She takes a breath, two, three, and then squares her shoulders. It's not time for this now. Emotions can wait.

"Can we, please, caliber the holo to my biometrics?"

The girl turns around, smiling, and takes the holo back.

“Can we also caliber it to Peter Quill’s biometrics? If it’s possible?“

“Oh, absolutely,” the girl says brightly. “We still have his data from when we scanned his body after the battle, so it shouldn’t take more than just couple of minutes.”

And she is right — it doesn’t.

It’s very shortly after that Gamora leaves the lab, going back upstairs to their apartments, clutching the holo close to her chest. Her heart is beating rapidly.

***

She finds them few drinks in, and the way Peter’s face lights up when he sees her, as if it everything is suddenly right now that she’s here, makes her stop breathing for a second.

“You came,” he says to her once she slides in the booth next to him.

Their thighs are touching. Her skin is burning from the contact.

“Of course I did.”

The smile he gives her is everything.

She reciprocates it, and he practically beams. The alcohol, as always, has made him more relaxed, more open, and now he’s more like himself, because his emotions are usually so easy to read, him being almost an open book, and she’s is just happy to see him enjoy himself for the first time in days.

A part of her is worried, however. She knows Peter. And she knows that alcohol brings everything to the surface for him. He seems to be relaxed now, practically content to be with their family next to him, with *her* next to him, but she knows that if he crosses the line, the alcohol will be his undoing.

She doesn’t want that to happen.

She wants him to let it all out more than anything. But she wants it to be in a safe space, safe environment, where she would be able to catch him and help him deal with the pain he’s been living with for all of his life.

So she stays close, keeping an eye out on all of his drinks, and she thinks it’s about an hour since she joined them when she gets a feeling that they need to leave.

His speech isn’t slurred yet, and his eyes are still sober enough, but his movements start getting a bit too slow, and she can feel the way his weight starts shifting onto her.

It’s welcome. Any contact is welcome.

But she knows it’s time to go.

So she takes his hand, interlacing their fingers, and he abruptly turns to her, immediately forgetting about a conversation he was having with Drax, and his eyes are wide.

He's not used to her initiating physical contact.

She's not used to that either. But it feels nice to do that.

To be open.

"Let's leave?" She suggests to him, smiling softly. "I want to show you something."

He nods, still not saying anything, and she hears the way his heart is beating. It's erratic. She made it this way.

She hopes it's a good sign. She doesn't know a sign of what, she just wants to believe that it's good. That he's good. They are good.

It takes them just a few minutes to get back to their apartments, and she leads him straight to her room, not even bothering to ask.

"Are you okay?" She asks him, once he sits on the bed, and she's asked him this question a million times in the last few days, but this time she means something else.

*Are you sober enough?*

As always, he gets it. He just knows what she means. He always does.

Nodding, he shifts slightly and takes off his boots. She is not sure how he knows, but he does. He knows that she wants him to stay, that this isn't just a quick conversation, and it's essentially another unspoken thing between them, but she just hopes it's going to be spoken really soon.

"What's up?" He asks her.

Her pulse picks up. This moment is significant. Every moment with Peter is, she knows it, believes it to be the most obvious fact of her life, but this is something even more.

She has never given a present to anyone in her life. And it's significant, *more than just important,* that Peter is the first person ever, because he's her first *everything,* and she wants him to know what he means to her, but she can't find words, and she just hopes he understands.

She wants him to know she's in it for the long run.

But even more than that, she wants him to believe that, too. She wants to push Ego's voice out of his head, ban it from there permanently, and she wants Peter to *believe.*

"I have something for you," she says to him, and his expression transforms into a mix of longing and fear.

He wants to have it.

He's also scared.

She just wants to hug him and take all the pain away.

"You didn't have to get me anything."

"I know. I wanted to," she smiles at him softly, trying to convey the intent through her eyes. He timidly smiles back. "Close your eyes."

He does.

It still amazes her how he always does what she asks him to. Even in the beginning.

He has never been scared of her. Has always trusted. It means more to her than she can ever put into words.

Taking the holopad from her wardrobe, she takes couple steps towards the bed and sits on the edge of it, opposite of Peter. Inhaling deeply, trying to calm her racing heart, she touches his wrist.

"You can open your eyes."

He does. Again, no questions asked, just following her lead. Her heart flutters.

"Here." She pushes the holo towards him, and he looks down at it, confusion slowly clouding his features. "It's… it's not what it looks like."

He looks back up at her, eyes full of unasked questions.

"I had it modified," she rushes to explain, but words get stuck. "It's…" she's struggling to find the right way to explain *this* — her intent, her attempt.

The speeches are his strong suit, not hers, and usually she's fine with that, but right now she wishes she had his talent.

"I know…" she takes a deep breath and tries again. "I know that everything that happened hasn't been easy for you," she reaches out and takes his hand, squeezing it, "and I know you haven't wanted to talk about it. And… I guess it's okay, because I don't want you to do something you're not ready for. I just… I want to be there for you, like you have been for me."

She can't believe how gentle, how vulnerable, how soft she is. With him. *For* him. *Because* of him. Just few months in his presence have awakened a part of her she didn't even know existed.

She's so grateful for that. For him.

Taking the holo with her second arm, she unlocks it, and turns the screen with all of the app towards Peter. He glances down briefly, still confused, seeing so many unfamiliar icons, and she continues.

“I can’t change what happened, but I thought I’d do something else. I asked Nova Prime if it would be possible to reprogram a holopad to access the Terran’s communication network, and it turned out to be possible.”

Her voice is barely a whisper at this point, emotions making it too thick.

“So, basically, it means that you have access to pretty much the majority of Terran movies — and music too, for that matter — and…” his breath hitches once her words register in his mind, and she feels him tighten the grip on her hand. She doesn’t know if he’s aware of his reaction.

“Gamora…” he says, voice full of awe and disbelief.

“I know you believe Ego took everything from you,” she says, and she sees a flash on anger, of pain in his eyes, so she rushes to continue. “I know that, because for the longest time I believed that to be true about Thanos. But someone,” she pointedly looks at him, “taught me that wasn’t the case.”

“He must be really smart,” Peter says.

“That he is,” Gamora says indulgently.

“He must be really hot too,” he says, this time with a hint of the usual confident cocky smile.

She rolls her eyes, but there’s no heat. There hasn’t been any heat directed at him for a while.

“I know you lost so much, Peter. Both emotionally and materialistically, but… this is something he can never take away from you. Not anymore. You *can* have it. You *can* have something you love. And you *should.* The movies, the music — these things are all parts of you, and you get to keep them with you, no matter what.”

He slowly looks up at her, and she sees tears flustering at his eyes. He tries to swallow, but he can’t, and he just looks at her, completely broken but also so hopeful, and the mix of these two emotions is familiar, because she is broken but hopeful too.

“And I… I don’t want to go anywhere,” she admits, reassures him in another way. “I want to stay.” She takes a deep breath to say what she wants. “I want to stay with you.” A tear slides down his cheek, and she gently brushes it off. He leans into her touch. “If there’s one thing to believe, you can believe this.”

It’s quiet between them, only his labored breath breaks the silence, and she feels light, having said all the things she wanted, having bared the soul to him, even if not to the full extent, and he looks at her, eyes piercing through her soul, and they’re having a moment, and it’s the best one, and she just… she feels so much for him.

The words, both new and very old, come into her mind, paralyzing and freezing her at the same time. They're pulsing intensively in her mind, affecting every cell in her body, but they just don't settle on her tongue, not now, and she's both frustrated and happy.

She wants to tell him.

She just never said it to anyone.

Knowing that Peter is going to be the first person makes her shiver. Knowing that he is going to be the *last* person — at least in the romantic sense — makes her feel peaceful. As if everything is finally right.

Peter is still silent, still stunned.

But she finds that she likes talking. When it's *with* him and *for* him, she likes doing many things.

"You can rewatch Footloose and all the Star Wars, if you want. And so many other new movies that came out… well, after."

She doesn't like to remind him of what Ego did, how he ruined Peter's life on Terra, and the words leave bitter taste in her mouth.

She grows silent, having opened up more than she ever had before, and he still looks at her, eyes full of awe and terror, a combination of disbelief and untamed hoped, and the moment prolongs for what feels like eternity.

Eventually, he looks down, breaking the eye contact, and it's stupid, but she almost feels the loss of that on a physical level. Taking a deep breath to contain her disappointment, she closes her eyes briefly, but when she opens them again, she see Peter tentatively reach out to take the holo.

He shifts, sliding backwards until his back is touching the walls, and she follows him like a moth to the flame, barely registering her own movements until she's sitting next to him, their thighs pressing together.

His fingers hover over the screen, and she can almost feel his need to press on the icon, to open up the app, to see for himself, but she can also feel a great self-constraint and reluctance.

"Do you want me to show you how to use it?" She asks after a second. "There are different apps for different movies."

He looks at her, amazed, hopeful, scared, and nods. She smiles at him, feeling a flutter of her heart. That is something she can help him with. That is something she can give him.

She clicks on the first one, and the screen is immediately filled with different pictures — movie posters, Peter had told her at some point in the past — and different titles. She quickly pulls up the search bar, typing Footloose, and she hears Peter's gasp.

She spends the next few minutes explaining to him how everything works, what Watchlist is, how to look for everything based on either actors or genre, and after she's done, his heart literally skips a beat and then the rhythm picks up.

Drastically.

His heart is beating rapidly, and she hears an actual gasp, a sob escaping his throat, and suddenly his whole body is shaking, and she feels her stomach clench from the sight in front of her, from the sounds reaching her ears, but he's finally letting it out.

She hugs him from the side, tightly grasping him, pressing into her own body, trying to make him as grounded as possible, and her own heart is absolutely breaking, she's terrified, she's scared, but he's *letting it out*, and she's *right here.*

She draws small circles on the skin of his arm, trying to give him as much comfort as possible. She whispers into his ear that it's going to be okay, and she doesn't even know if he hears her, but she keeps saying the words anyways because it *is* going to be okay, it *has to,* and she has to believe it herself because there's simply no other option.

After a while, she manages to reposition them, to make him lie down, and she's still right there, right next to him, pressing tightly against his body, her nose in his neck, her fingers splayed against his back, and he's still shaking and still gasping for air.

She's crying too. But silently. Because this is about him.

It hurts to hear his pain, his raw hysterical cry, but he's letting it all out.

She doesn't know how much time passes, she just knows that it does, and she hears the others come home from the bar and go into their own rooms, and Peter is latching onto her, gripping tightly the material of her shirt in his hands, but then, long after he started, he finally calms down, his sobs slowly quieting down.

They stay silent, him still sniffling, her hair, her face getting dry from his tears that slid down onto her skin from where the top of her head was touching his chin. From also all of her tears she silently had. The sky behind the glass starts changing the color, getting less dark with each minute.

Another day is taking over the night.

A new beginning after a seemingly infinite darkness.

Somehow, that's symbolic. It's fitting.

She hopes that today *is* a new beginning after the infinite darkness they lived in.

She moves slightly, tilting her head backwards to look up at him, and he looks down, feeling her move, and his eyes are red-rimmed, full of pain, but they're no longer vacant, no longer detached, no longer both scared and hopeful, no longer full of denial, and this moment, his obvious exhaustion but also a hint of freedom in his eyes, makes it all worth.

The pain is there. It would be foolish to believe it can go away just like that. But everything else, everything poisoning and mind messing, is less present.

“Do you want some tea?” She offers, her voice hoarse. The last thing she wants to do is leave him alone, but she knows that tea is his comfort. For that, she will leave the bed a million times.

He shakes his head.

“No,” he whispers back. “I just want you.”

Her heart soars.

“You have me.”

And then he nods, and this reaction, his silent agreement rather than a blatant and loud refusal dictated by fears and Ego’s voice and everything else that’s happened to him, makes her tear up once again.

But this time, it’s happy.

They’re going to be okay.

There’s a long way towards that, but at least there is a way.

She hugs him tighter, pressing him into her body, and he hugs her back just as tightly, and she practically melts. They don’t talk after that, but holding him and having him hold her just as eagerly is enough.

It’s okay.

And soon, it’s going to be good. They’re going to be good.

Chapter End Notes

**hope you liked this chapter. please let me know if you did.**
**i'm going to update next week, some time between monday and wednesday :)**

# Chapter 3: chapter 3

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

After that night — *the* night — everything changes. For good, this time, though. Peter is still not okay, and he has demons crawling at him, Ego's voice still echoing in his head — *he killed my mom,* he rasps sometimes at night, tears blistering in his eyes — but he's doing better.

With every movie watched, with every new song discovered, with every touch she initiates, he's doing better.

He is still scared good things — *her,* the team — will be taken away. If anything, last night — when he voiced his fears to her in the middle of the night, when she was pressed against his body, hearing his erratic heartbeat — was a proof of that.

But while there is still fear, there is no *denying* himself anymore. There is no more depriving and consciously avoiding.

*He killed my mom,* he whispers to her at night, voice broken, small, desperate.

But there is also *I'm done letting him win.* There is *I won't let him scare me after he is gone.* There is *eff you, you major a-hole.*

And then there is determination in his voice, when he says all these things. And she believes him.

Because he opens up.

He shares.

He seeks her out for comfort — rather than avoiding her to hide his pain — and he is her comfort, and lately it's looked like she might be his, and the idea tugs at her heart, keeping her warm from the inside.

After couple more weeks — since that night when she gave him a present — they decide to go back to Quadrant. Once the shock and the fear and the feeling of despair remain just a dull memory, rather than a sharp, acutely pulsing reminder, they return to the ship.

It's just like in the past.

But also not.

Somehow they fall into a routine.

The days are reserved for jobs, still relatively easy ones — the open wounds might be gone, but the scars still remain. It's all about the actions that bring a sense of *more.* Not necessarily

a sense of right, but just *more,* something to relieve the constant dull ache caused by the demons and the memories.

Sincere attempts to change the past and make it all better.

The nights, though — the nights are for the sense of *right.* For the sense of *peace* and *belonging* and *learning* because they always end up in his captain quarters — another unspoken things *in the long list of things that haven't discussed yet* — and they both learn about the Terran culture.

They watch the movies, and he plays them songs, and they discover YouTube, and Peter gets absolutely obsessed with the app, spending hours watching the most ridiculous videos ever.

(Rocket might have made fun of him for that, but after he discovered the app had videos of explosions, he shut up. Gamora pretends she doesn't notice him stealing the holo sometimes. She also ignores the search history.

Neither of them also acknowledge that she contacted Nova Corps to add his biometrics to the holo at some point.)

And somehow it's just right.

*Everything* about it is.

Peter rediscovering new things about his culture — a *tie* to his mother, now prevalent more than ever.

Her *learning together* with him.

Him *wanting* her to know more.

Her *craving* those quiet nights when it's just the two of them, with everything in her.

Him finally being *excited* about things.

Them practically living together.

She doesn't know how it happened, she just knows that it did. Ever since that night, the first night when *she* had a breakdown, but most certainly the night *he* did, they ended up spending the nights together.

There was no discussion. No confessions. Just hopeful eyes and longing expressions. She wants to think that just on his part, but she knows that would be a lie.

She is transparent. She knows. Everyone knows. She doesn't care.

She can't help but think of what she told him all those months ago, "I am not some starry-eyed waif here to succumb to your pelvic sorcery!", and how much has changed.

She hasn't fallen to *that,* per se, but she also hasn't spent a night away from him in weeks now, and despite everything, despite the belief almost *embodied* in her bones that everything she is feeling is a weakness, she can't — *doesn't* want to — to change anything.

Not after learning how much she has gained when she let herself open up. Not after learning about life, about him, about *herself.* Not after finally knowing peace, a quiet emptiness in her own mind — the one she thought she'd never have.

All thanks to him. *Because* of him. And she is overwhelmed with how much she feels for him.

And she is incredibly mad for not being able to voice it.

How hard can it be after all, right? She told him how she feels with *everything* else, with every action, every touch, every intention — with everything but words. And she wants to. She does. She just *can't* because somehow it's scary, the words get stuck in her throat, and there is a lot of doubts *what if he doesn't feel the same,* which she knows is ridiculous, but she just *can't.*

It makes her angry, anxious and annoyed.

And then Peter makes it all better, *of course he does,* because that's just him, and he makes it *all* better for her, most often even not being aware of that.

After releasing her frustration on the punching bag in their gym, she goes straight to the shower and then to Peter's room, both wanting to see him and dreading the moment, because seeing him makes her want to say those words even more, but the inability to do so drives her crazy.

But when she opens the door, she finds him sprawled out on the bed, watching what she has learned to be Castle. She finds the show kinda ridiculous, but after watching some of the episodes together with Peter she gets it why he loves it so much.

He would be best friends with Castle.

She opens her mouth to complain — half heartedly at best, because okay, the show isn't that bad and as long as Peter is enjoying, she will *never* complain, because seeing him happy makes *everything* okay, but then she stops in her tracks, when she hears the dialogue.

"How do you know when you're in love?" Castle asks.

"All the songs make sense," Beckett replies nonchalantly.

And then it hits her, and her heart stops for a second, and she can't believe she didn't think of that herself, because it's just brilliant, and her breath hitches.

They do. The songs *do* make sense now. She's listened to what feels like a thousand of them lately, and every song about love just seems about him, *and* her, *and* them, and she hadn't known what love was, had never experienced it, but somehow, somewhere along the way,

even before the holopad and the access to the Terran *everything,* she figured it out, because the songs *did* make sense.

Ever since the first few times he played something for her.

She must make a sound, pretty sure can't contain half a gasp leaving her lips, because this is so obvious, and he looks at her with confusion.

"Hey, are you okay?"

She nods.

She is. She is more than okay.

Because music is his *everything.* A connection to his mother. A connection to a part of him — or maybe, more accurately, a whole of him, since the celestial gene is gone. A love language — a phrase she learned thanks to one of the videos they both watched.

And he will *get* it. She can tell him without voicing her feelings, without her throat constricting, literally preventing her from breathing, and he will get it, and she feels a rush of adrenaline and excitement, because all the songs make sense and he will know.

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She spends the next few days trying to create a playlist for him, and it's hard, because every love song remind her of him, but she wants it to be more than just that, she wants it to be special and just feel right.

She has never given a present to anyone in her life. Not until the holopad, anyways.

But this — a second gift in her life — feels too important. She can't mess this up.

And then she comes across a song — something she never heard before — and everything just *clicks*.

*So I*
*I try*
*To find the reasons I should walk away*
*'Cause I don't wanna want you like I do*
*But I can't help falling' for you*

And she thinks about the beginning.

She remembers resisting. She remembers spending nights with him at the cockpit on Milano, just them and the quietness of night, feeling like she *belonged,* which scared her more than anything ever had before, more than Thanos had ever scared her because the feeling was new, it was unknown, it was over consuming, and it left her craving more.

Of him.

Of nights like this.

Of the easy flow between them.

Of the want to share.

Of the want to open up.

Of the happiness she felt when he did the same.

And she remembers hating feeling this way — *trying* to convince herself she hated it — feeling so soft and vulnerable, because assassins should never feel like that, and she made herself ignore him, snap at him, put up more walls for days after those nights.

And then, a week later, when she would wake up from another nightmare, all she craved was him — his gentle eyes, his easy demeanour, his jokes that she pretended to hate but secretly loved because they chased the demons away.

And then she would seek him out.

And then she would open up.

And then she would punish herself — *deprive* herself of him — the next day.

And a week later everything would repeat.

Because *I can't help falling' for you*

Feeling her heart in her throat, she creates a playlist with shaking fingers, adding this first song, because the importance of the moment isn't lost on her. Peter's mom used to make mixtapes for him. She is making a somewhat similar thing now.

She knows this song isn't his style, the music and the tone is so different from what he had come to love having Walkman, but it still feels right.

She names the playlist For you, not having enough creativity to come up with something better, nervousness and excitement and worry all mixed up inside her, preventing her from thinking straight, not that she ever was a creative person in the first place.

That has always been Peter's thing.

He is the heart.

She is the head.

And maybe it's why they work so perfectly together.

Because they compliment each other without having to sacrifice parts of themselves to be together. She doesn't know much about love and relationships — he's way more familiar

with that, and it does make her feel torn that there were others in his life, as stupid as it is — but she's sure that that's how it should be.

It shouldn't be a sacrifice. It should be comfort.

It is.

*Not* that they are in a relationship like she keeps seeing in movies.

Because she's scared. She longs to have that, but she's so scared. And he's patient, following her lead. He hugs her, they sleep on the same bed, but she is terrified of the next step. She's an assassin, for heaven's sake, she is not terrified of anything, but she's terrified of *this* — the thing she wants *the most* in the world.

But she refuses to let the fear take over her completely. They live the lives of danger. They all know the risks and the lack of promise of tomorrow. And that — this heartbreaking and sobering realization — is the thing that keeps pushing her forward, slightly loosening all those strings in her chest. It's that realization that makes it easier to hug him longer with each passing day or look at his lips, *even* when he's watching her.

It's the realization that she might loose him that makes her want to battle her own demons.

And when she finds another song that perfectly describes what she's *feeling* but can't *articulate,* another wave of peace washes over her. It's like another piece fits the picture perfectly.

*I woke up in tears with you by my side*
*A breath of relief, and I realized*
*No, we're not promised tomorrow*
*So I'm gonna love you like I'm gonna lose you*

Her entire body aches when she listens to the lyrics. Because Thanos is still there, he's still a threat, just waiting out to ambush her when she least expects it, but even the absolute certainty that *he will* doesn't stop her from feeling what she does for Peter.

She can't *not* feel those things for him.

Not when his every touch leaves her longing for more. Not when she makes a joke that makes him laugh. Not when *that* leaves her proud and happy, absolutely content that she somehow managed to make him smile.

The days are numbered, she knows, but…

*Wherever we're standing, I won't take you for granted*
*'Cause we'll never know when,*
*When we'll run out of time*

She almost lost him multiple times. In the beginning, when he grabbed the Stone from Ronan. Then later, *twice* that day with Ego. All those multiple times when they were facing danger during the jobs…

There's always a risk.

And she *hates* them. She hates not being the one in control. She hates not being able to come up a perfect foolproof plan.

But he makes it worth it, he makes the unknown and the risk worth it because when he smiles at her, she is ready to do *anything* to spend even another moment in his presence. Dangerous future and logic be damned.

She *will* lose him one day. This leaves her sad and anxious, but she pushes the thought out of her mind. For now, she can love him with everything in her.

She can love him like she might lose him tomorrow.

Because he is *everything.*

And it's when she comes across *Dandelions* that she feels another piece click into its rightful place. It's when she is, once again, hit with the strength of her feelings. It's when she's listening to the lyrics written by someone else — somehow who experienced this kind of love — that her body comes to life, suddenly having a benchmark. Having something to relate to, to name all those crazy flips of her heart that she's experiencing on a daily basis.

*Maybe it's the way you say my name*
*Maybe it's the way you play your game*
*But it's so good, I've never known anybody like you*

And she hasn't.

Ever since he came to her rescue in Kyln, even if he was driven by the desire to sell the Orb, he has been different. But it was when he asked them all to die for the right thing that she felt like she found what she was looking for.

Her righteousness almost became her undoing, her guilt eating her alive while she kept serving Thanos and being the *monster* he made her out to be. But it is also what drove her to betray him in the first place. It's *his* righteousness that made her look at him differently. Not through curiosity or confusing physical attraction she never felt before. But through a sudden sense of *he gets it*.

And he does.

It's his belief — something she also believes in with everything in her — that helped make this team a *team*. And later, a *family.*

*I've heard of a love that comes in a lifetime*
*And I'm pretty sure that you're that love of mine*

Her heart squeezes in her chest at the lyrics. She never thought she would ever feel *that,* but now that she does, she can't imagine having it any other way. She can't imagine not loving Peter, and the thought sends shivers down her body, because it's the first time she's voiced her feelings as they are.

But saying it — even if it's just in her own head — feels right. The warmth is spreading through her body instantly, making her feel like she's covered in a safe blanket.

She's hungrily listening to the rest of the lyrics, her heart soaring in her chest.

*Thump. Thump. THUMP.*

*I love him. I love him. I love him so much.*

*I see forever in your eyes*
*I feel okay when I see you smile, smile*

Tears burn her eyelids. She feels ashamed for being so emotional and tries to swallow her emotions down, even if no one is there, but then she thinks of the *I'm gonna love you like I'm gonna lose you* and lets her love for him to take over.

He deserves the full spectrum of her emotions. He deserves to be shown how much he is loved. He deserves *everything,* and she wants to be that everything. She wants to show him how much he means to *her* — and to the Universe too.

She wants him to believe *her* and not the cold voices he still hears sometimes in his head.

If she needs to be so vulnerable and open for that, then so. be. it.

He's worth it.

She would do anything for him.

It's overwhelming to feel so much.

But so right.

Her whole body is on fire — but this time, it's a *good* feeling. All she wants to find him and wrap her whole body around him and to never let go.

There's another song that she comes across — *Infinity.*

*Oh, darling, my soul*
*You know it aches for you*
*'Cause you're the reason I believe in fate, you're my paradise*

She immediately adds it to the playlist.

Tears keep falling, and she brushes them off, but this time not in attempt to hide them, but simply to be able to see the screen. And the change in her — the openness she's projecting, even if no one's around — is so drastic she can't help but think of how she used to be.

Walls high up. Guarded. Cautions.

Scared of living.

Scared of even *thinking of living.*

Resistant to anything good.

Fully convinced of being unworthy.

And she still is, she *is,* but he makes the doubts go away sometimes. Every time he reminds her of her own good, of everything she's doing to keep the Universe save, every time he *practically growls* that she's not Thanos' daughter when her nightmares get the best of her, her walls come down.

Because he's soothing a pain in her chest that she didn't even think could be soothed. But it can. Because he placates her deepest fears of not being enough.

*You are everything, Gamora,* he told her couple night ago. His eyes were sincere. His voice was kind, but authoritative. Everything in him screamed *he* believed that.

Another crack in her heart healed that night. It wasn't gone, the scar is *stil*l there and *always* will be, but the crack stopped bleeding. It simply became a reminder of the past. Not an itch taking up all space in her mind.

*Remember those walls I built?*
*Well, baby, they're tumblin' down*
*And they didn't even put up a fight*
*They didn't even make a sound*

No. They didn't. They never had a chance against his warm smile and gentle touch.

*I found a way to let you in*
*But I never really had a doubt*
*Standin' in the light of your halo*
*I got my angel now*

She looks at the title of the song. It's called *Halo.* She immediately adds it to her playlist and then closes her eyes to absorb the music, the rhythm, the words the singer is using.

*It's like I've been awakened*
*Every rule I had you breakin'*
*It's the risk that I'm takin'*
*I ain't never gonna shut you out*

No, she will *never* do that. She never wants to do it, to shut him out. She did it in the past, when they just started, when there wasn't even a them, but only because she *didn't* want to shut him out. So she ended up doing that, being terrified of the flips of her heart she had never experienced before.

*Everywhere I'm lookin' now*
*I'm surrounded by your embrace*
*Baby, I can see your halo*

*You know you're my saving grace*
*You're everything I need and more*

A sob escapes her lips, her whole chest wide open. But in a good, in a *very* good — in the *best* — way. She's been suppressing her feelings for months — which feels like an eternity — but her body refuses to keep hiding them anymore.

It's letting go. *She* is letting go. Of grief, of fear, of every insecurity she had. She's letting go of everything that's been holding her back.

She doesn't want any of those things in her anymore.

All she wants is *love.*

Because she loves him.

She *loves* him.

She loves him *so* much.

The words — once so reluctant to be said even in the confined space of her own mind — are demanding to be released. Not just silently. But to him.

The need to tell him *now* washes over her, the urgency and the importance making her head spin. She feels like she's going to combust if she doesn't tell him now, but she's crying, for heaven's sake, and there's a lump in her throat, and she can't say anything, but she absolutely *has to.*

She loves him more than anything, and he should *know.*

He deserves that.

He deserves to hear every day about the impact he has on this Universe. On *her.*

He deserves to hear how much he's loved.

And it's like he's in tune — *they* are in tune — because it's when he enters the captains quarter. The smile he has on his face immediately disappears, though, when he sees the way her body shakes.

"Gamora," he is in front of her instantly, sliding down next to her. "What's going on, baby?"

The pet name slips easily off his lips, and he has never called that before, but she suddenly loves it and can't wait to hear it another million times in the future. The gentle tone of his voice makes her cry even harder, though.

"Gamora," he pleads, not knowing what's happening. "What happened?"

"Nothing," she manages to breath out. "Nothing bad, I promise."

She tries to look at him, to show the sincerity of her words through her eyes, but they're full of tears. He grips her face in his big warm hands and strokes her cheekbones.

The affection of his touch breaks down another wall. Another fear.

She loves him so much.

"What can I do?"

She loves him. She loves *that.* She loves how he asks her, pays attention to whatever she has to say. She loves how he puts her needs first.

He mends her soul without even realizing it.

She needs to tell him.

She *loves* him.

Taking a deep breath, she tries to calm down enough to say the words, but the intensity of her feelings, of her breakdown is too strong. She can't fight it. Now now.

So she clutches his t-shirt in her fingers and whispers, "Hold me."

He does.

No questions asked, he lies down, tugging her with him, and she ends up with her head on his chest, listening to the sound of his heartbeat under her cheek.

It's the most soothing sound in the entire world.

He's alive.

He's here.

*I'm gonna love you like I'm gonna lose you*

*But I can't help falling' for you*

*I see forever in your eyes*

*You're my paradise*

The lyrics keep playing in her head, making her lightheaded, but also so grounded, making her feel so much but not enough — because *nothing* is going to be enough until she tells him how she feels.

But she doesn't want to say the words to him when she's like this. She wants to let go of everything bad and tell him when there's nothing but light in her. Nothing but *love.*

So she waits it out, letting his heartbeat soothe her, and eventually she calms down enough. When that happens, she sits up on the bed, smiling down at him.

He's concerned, his eyes full of sadness. For her. His attunement to her is overwhelming and so welcome. She doesn't want to worry him though.

"'Mora," the nickname is barely a whisper. "What—"

"I'm fine," she interrupts him. Because she *is.* The heaviness of the past is not fully gone, but she feels lighter than before.

"Then why—"

She shakes her head, interrupting him again. She's ready to explain about the playlist, but other words leave her mouth.

"I love you."

A second. Two. Three. The room is silent, but then his heart accelerates, he exhales, and she is suddenly feeling lighter than she thought would *ever* be possible.

A wide smile erupts on her face.

And she feels complete.

"I love you," she says again.

Who could even think that being so vulnerable and honest would make her feel *so invincible?*

His mouth opens. For everything they've been doing lately and how comfortable they've gotten around each other, they never discussed *them* so openly. They never mentioned the world love either. Not since Mantis announced his feelings all these weeks ago.

But now she goes all the way in.

Because she *is* all the way in.

And it feels liberating.

She feels so alive.

He swallows. She beams at him. It's still silent.

And then he sits up too. He lunges forward, and the next second his lips are on hers. And then she doesn't have *any* words to describe the feeling of finally kissing the person she *loves.* The movies and songs described it as sparks. As magic. But that doesn't cover *anything* she's feeling at all.

It's the *flame* that is licking up and down her body, that *consumes* her. His hands fly to her face, one cupping her cheek, another one disappearing in her hair, and she moans — she *moans* for heaven's sake — but his *lips,* his *fingers* leave her burning, leave her combusting into flames, and she disappears, her soul leaving her body.

All senses are alive. Wired.

Focused solely on him.

Every touch sends a bolt of electricity through her body.

He slides his hand down, stopping at her lower back, and he presses her even closer to him. Closer. Closer. *Closer.* She's practically on him, but that's not enough.

Nowhere near enough.

She slides her hands up until they're behind his neck. She presses him closer to herself too.

He moans.

She gasps.

He bites on her lower lip.

She comes alive.

His heart beats loudly.

Hers too.

He feels like a live wire. It's just as impossible to loosen up your fingers and let go.

She doesn't want to, though.

Not anymore.

*Never.*

She wants to spend the whole eternity like this.

Wrapped around him. Surrounded by him.

She tugs at his hair. He groans. She loves the sound.

He strokes her cheek.

She gasps in his mouth.

She can feel his smirk.

She's smiling too.

And then the kiss grows slow. The urgency is gone — or maybe, slightly dissolved — and there's nothing but tenderness and affection, and she's losing her breath — and she has body mods for that, *what the hell* — and she can't breathe anymore.

She doesn't break the kiss, though.

He does.

"Mora," he whispers into her mouth. She doesn't know where his breath ends and hers begins. And that's more than fine with her. He kisses her again the next second.

Her head is spinning.

Then, he tries again.

"Mora," he whispers breathlessly.

*She* kisses him this time.

She doesn't ever want to stop.

He doesn't either, it seems.

At some point, he needs to take a breath. She knows that, but she's still disappointed when he moves back slightly. Even an inch is too much of a distance.

She doesn't want to have any.

"Gamora."

His voice is full of awe. Her heart flips. She looks at him, and his eyes are shining bright. The absolute happiness is so evident in them that her breath bitches in her throat.

*Me. I made him this happy.*

The voice in her head makes her proud. Makes her smile. She cups his face.

"I'm sorry it took me this long."

He's speechless. He's breathing hard, his chest heaving with each breath he takes, expanding rapidly. His lips are red. His face is *ecstatic.*

She can't believe she hadn't told him sooner.

But she doesn't want to have any regrets. Not now. Not when the moment is *everything.*

He still keeps staring at her. And she can't help but tease him, "If I knew *this* would shut you up, I would have done it a long time ago."

This seems to break whatever he's under, and he laughs. The voice echoes in their — yes, *their* — room, and she can't help a wide smile spreading on her face. It's her favorite sound. Along with the soothing beat of his heart. And his whispered Mora.

"Give the man a break," he laughs, eyes glinting. "It's not every day the most amazing woman in the galaxy tells him she loves him."

“If you play your cards right, you might get to hear that every day,” she winks at him.

He groans, “You’re perfect.”

And she’s far from it, but when he looks at her like *this,* she *believes* him. Anything that’s not him fades into the background, and there’s only him, only her, only *them,* and this incredible feeling she finally knows why people write songs about.

It’s uplifting.

Like nothing else ever is.

And then it gets even better.

“I love you.”

Her heart *stops.* Then, starts galloping. She didn’t think it would be possible to be happier than she was a second ago, but it *is.* However, the euphoria that instantly blooms in her chest is gone as abruptly as it came. Instead, it is replaced by the feeling of *right.*

It’s a calm wave of certainty that never comes from anything else. Only from the belief that *this is how it should be.*

She feels safe.

She feels like she belongs.

And not to. But *with.*

She feels warm.

She feels validated.

Cared for. Adored. Cherished.

*Loved.*

She hopes he can feel all the same.

The world is still ends and begins with him. With *them* — him and her, here, in this room. This is theirs, and it’s *perfect,* and it’s *home,* and it’s *security.*

It’s everything he showed her she can have, and it’s everything she hopes he believes he can have too.

She leans down to kiss him again. He meets her halfway, and she suddenly knows he will *always* meet her halfway.

She feels peace.

“I love you.”

***

She doesn't know how much time passes, but she ends up pressed against him in *their* bed, in *their* room. Her face is tucked under his chin, and her hand lays on his chest. His heart is beating steadily underneath.

"I had a surprise for you," she tells him after a while.

He hums.

"What you gave me was the best surprise ever."

She scoffs.

"Trust me, you're so dramatic, you would have loved it."

"I'm not dramatic!"

"He said dramatically," she scoffs. "Peter, you're the most dramatic person I have ever met."

"You just didn't meet a lot of people," he pouts.

"Oh, that must be the reason then," she says dryly.

He chuckles. She can feel the rumble in his chest under her cheek, and it makes her smile. She somehow feels ever closer to him this way — when she can feel the laugh, not just hear it.

"What was the surprise?" He asks, his curiosity peaked. "But you didn't have to do it."

"I know," she says. "I really wanted to."

She sits up, and the smile she sees on his face is her undoing. She melts.

"You deserve to know how much you're loved," she tells him simply. His smile fades, but not in a bad way.

She can tell how much he's touched. His eyes cloud with tears. She cups his face.

"You're everything, Peter."

She can't believe how soft she is. More than that, she can't believe how *right* it feels.

He grabs her hand and brings it up to his mouth. Pressing a kiss against her knuckles that leaves her beyond breathless, he whispers, "I have no idea what I did to deserve you, Mora."

She has so many things to say to that, but she also wants to make something clear to him — something she is sure he still doesn't fully believe in. Something that all of his traumas and pains of the past make him forget about.

“You didn’t have to do anything, baby.” The pet names feels natural on her lips. By the way his eyes widen, he’s surprised. But the relief on his face tells her he loved it just as much as she did. “You existing is already enough. I don’t love you for what you did. I love you because of you.”

He closes her eyes — probably to control his emotions. She’s stroking his cheek, patiently waiting for him to overcome the lump he might be feeling. She has one too. But it’s not strong enough to stop her from speaking her truth. Nothing will *ever* stop her from letting him know how important he is.

When he opens his eyes, the tears fall free. She just smiles at him, hoping he can see in her eyes that it’s safe to come undone.

He was the one who taught her that.

He’s the one who showed her that being vulnerable is the strongest thing you can do. Because once you are, you have *this*.

“I love you more than anything, Mora.”

“I love you just as much,” she whispers.

He leans towards her and kisses her. This time, it’s relatively chaste, not going anywhere, not leading up to anything. It’s just a way to physically connect with someone who your soul belongs with.

When she breaks the kiss, he groans. But she smiles at him.

“Come on, I still have the present.”

He perks up at that.

She grabs the holo from the floor and extends it to him. But before he can take it from her, she withdraws her hand.

“I… I got the inspiration from Beckett.”

He raises his eyebrows.

“Come again?”

“When she said that songs start making sense once you’re in love, I got an idea. I didn’t know how to tell you I loved you without having to actually say the words, so I decided to use the language you know.”

She pushes the holo towards him, and when he unlocks it, it’s open to the page of the playlist she created for him. He looks down, slightly confused, and then looks back up at her.

“I know you love your music,” she tells him. “And… I wanted to let you know how I felt using what you love the most. I know I already said the words,” shivers run down her spine at

the memory, “but it’s still hard for me to express the full extent of my feelings. So…” she trails off. “I hope the songs would tell you what I can’t.“

He looks at her like she’s the biggest wonder in the Universe. Like she’s the gift of incredible value. Like nothing else matters, and like he can’t believe he’s the lucky one to stumble upon it.

Her heart stops.

“Mora…” He whispers.

“I know I didn’t add a lot of songs,” she says, regret briefly seeping into her tone.

“It doesn’t matter,” he shakes his head. “You’ve done this for me. It means the entire world. It doesn’t matter how many songs the playlist has.”

She smiles timidly. Now that he’s about to listen to the songs that describe everything she’s feeling — even if it’s not news to him anymore — she gets nervous. She doesn’t know why.

She just know that she *does*. Not enough to run away. But enough to tremble on the inside.

But when he clicks on one of the songs, and the first notes and lyrics of *Infinity* fill the space around them, his face shows *everything*.

It’s not even wonder. It’s something deeper. Something she doesn’t know how to name.

But it’s something she feels every time she looks at him, not fully grasping how someone like him came into her life.

It’s gratitude. And love. And something else too.

It’s *warmth*.

When he looks at her, his eyes are clouded with tears again. And when she holds his gaze, she knows how he looks at her. And how she looks at him.

How they look *at each other*.

Home.

They look at each other like they’re each other’s home.

And they are.

Chapter End Notes

**i know this story is an au because it's canon that starmora kissed the night of y's funeral, but i just couldn't resist exploring this idea of gamora's guilt (because she is the one who pushed him to go to ego) and his pain (because come on he lost so much, i can't imagine him just brushing it all off). plus i really wanted to explore soft gamora who reassures and supports peter, so this baby was born. i didn't enjoy writing it as much as "you're in my veins", but it's my fav story out of the ones i've written so far, even the ones i haven't published yet.**

**i really want to write jealousy one/two-shots (where both peter and gamora are jealous) and i have multiple multi chapter ideas (i will be posting snippets on here this week to hold myself accountable to actually finish them), but for now there's nothing else fully written (i have a bunch of stories i started but never continued tho).**

**i hope you enjoyed this story, please let me know if you did, comments make me the happiest and i always smile like a big goof <3**

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!